

Challenge

Managing time off should be simple, but many leave-management platforms still feel centered on administration rather than on the employee experience. TIMEOFF.GURU is strong in core functionality such as leave requests, approvals, reports, calendars, exports, integrations, and configuration, but the product also shows how quickly these systems can become process-heavy when they need to serve employees, managers, HR, and payroll at the same time.

Product context

TIMEOFF.GURU positions itself as a platform for planning employee time off with requests, approvals, calendar overview, settings, locations, reports, mobile access, and integrations with tools like Google Calendar, iCal, and Outlook. It also supports configurable approval processes, multiple leave types, notifications, reports, and exports to Excel.

Main problems identified

1. The experience is efficient, but very administrative.
The platform clearly focuses on submitting requests, passing them through approval steps, notifying stakeholders, and generating reports. That is useful for operations, but it can make the experience feel like a system for processing absences rather than helping people confidently plan time away.
2. Complexity grows quickly behind the scenes.
The manual shows detailed settings for approval flows, substitutes, extra notifications, request rules, templates, and different absence types. This level of flexibility is powerful, but it can also create friction for first-time users, managers, or admins who need to understand many rules before they feel in control.
3. Calendar readability can become overloaded.
The calendar uses full fills, edge colors, legends, hover states, and multiple visual markers to show personal leave, sick leave, and colleagues’ absences. In small teams this may work well, but in larger teams or busy periods it can become harder to scan quickly and understand at a glance. This is an interface-design inference based on the documented calendar behavior.
4. Different user roles create competing needs.
The product serves employees, managers, HR, finance, and leadership, each with different goals. Employees want speed and clarity, managers want team visibility, and HR/payroll want reports and control. TIMEOFF.GURU supports all of these, but combining them in one system increases the risk of dense navigation and feature-heavy screens. This is an inference from the role-specific feature set described on the site.
5. The system prioritizes control and reporting more than planning confidence.
Reports are extensive, including status, type, location, sick leave, absenteeism, approval timing, and detailed exports. That makes the product strong for administration, but it suggests an opportunity to improve the emotional side of planning time off: helping users feel reassured, informed, and aware of team context before they submit a request. This is also an inference from the public feature emphasis.

Problem Statement

Users need a simpler and more intuitive way to plan time off without navigating complex settings, approval logic, and visually overloaded calendars.

Problem Solution

New version that improves clarity, reduces friction, and makes time-off planning more user-centered, helping employees and managers make decisions faster and with more confidence.

Design Goals

Simplify the request flow so employees can understand what they need to do with minimal effort. Improve visibility so users can quickly see balances, team availability, and request status. Reduce visual overload by making calendars and key information easier to scan. Support all roles clearly without making the interface feel crowded or difficult to learn. Create a calmer experience that feels modern, efficient, and trustworthy.

Key Improvements

Compared to the original experience, the redesign introduces:

- clearer page structure
- improved hierarchy and readability
- more intuitive time-off request flow
- better visibility of approval tasks
- stronger distinction between employee and manager views
- more organized profile and user management experience
- mobile-friendly layouts for flexibility and accessibility